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TRAINS OF PROGRESS AND POLITICS

From Dramatic Sackings to Building Engineeing Marvels

RAIL BOARD CHIEF WHO WAS SACKED WHILE ON THE TRAIN

Bankim Chandra Ganguli, a visionary, strict disciplinarian and no-nonsense officer, was one of the idols of railway icon E. Sreedharan. It was Ganguli who, as general manager of Southern Railway, called upon Sreedharan and advanced the six-month deadline of the restoration of the Pamban bridge to three months. Sreedharan, who had immense respect for Ganguli, did not say no out of respect and completed the project much earlier.

But sadly, Ganguli's case turned out to be gloomy in the Indian Railways' history due to his dramatic dismissal by the Railway Minister in the 1970s. Rarely has a top government official been given the boot in as bizarre a fashion as he was. The incident has been described in *Time* magazine in detail.

> This was in 1971. There had been differences between Railway Minister Kengal Hanumanthaiya, 63, a Karnataka politician, and Ganguli, who was then the Railway Board Chairman. As time went by, the differences widened. On 8 October 1971, Ganguli, who had scheduled a nine-day inspection tour of Gujarat, had just got in, along with his wife and personal staff, in his air-conditioned inspection saloon coach at Sarai Rohilla attached to a train that was to leave.
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> The station officials received a communication from the minister's office, getting the coach detached minutes before the train's departure. An angry Ganguli called for a press conference on the station platform and stayed in the coach in protest for six days. On 12 October 1971, the government issued an order to forcibly retire Ganguli, and officials